



▲ WARFARE

Maya leaders displayed their fitness to rule through their success in warfare. The aim was not to kill enemies, but to capture them for later sacrifice to the gods. Maya warriors often wore jaguar headdresses and skins into battle to symbolize victory, as shown in this painting from a Maya site in Mexico.



The ball was made of hard rubber.

◀ SACRED BALL GAME

Like earlier civilizations in the region, the Maya played a ball game that was both a sport and a religious ceremony in honor of the gods. Every Maya city had ball courts for the game. This figurine shows a Maya ballplayer.

The mask is made of 300 jade tiles on a wooden frame.



◀ PRECIOUS JADE

To the Maya, jade was more precious than gold. It was valued for its beautiful green color, which was believed to be linked to water, vegetation, and life itself. The Maya king Pakal the Great was buried with a jade mask (left), which represented his transformation into a god.

Jade necklace

MAJOR PERIODS

1800 BCE–250 CE

The first Maya villages appear around 1800 BCE. By around 500 BCE, these have begun to grow into large cities with ceremonial centers. The Maya also develop a system of writing.

250–950 CE

Maya civilization reaches its height. Cities are ruled by powerful kings who build monuments that record the date of their kingdoms.

950–1520 CE

Following a long period of drought, cities in the central rainforest are abandoned. However, Maya cities in the north and south of the region continue to grow.

1520–1697

Spanish colonists invade the region, but face fierce resistance from the Maya. It takes the colonists almost 200 years to complete their invasion.

BEFORE 500 CE